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Personal Essay

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The Night Trucks

The cattle trucks came at night so that they would arrive at the stockyards in the morning. Their lights down our long driveway in late winter cut shadows across the upstairs bedroom where my brothers and I slept, the web of the naked elm in the front yard moving slowly over the walls like an ineffective net. Shadows of crooked branches slid over the wall above my bed, over the ceiling, over my sleeping brothers, over the model cars and airplanes we had built and placed on shelves, over the chifforobe where we each had a drawer to store personal things. The gray Formica kitchen table with its wavy patterns of white seemed almost to disappear in the moving shadows. It had come to our room after Dad brought home from an auction sale the great black wooden table that had made Mom cry when she saw it, but which she couldn't refuse because the family had grown too large for the smaller table.

The shadows made the bedroom seem underwater, light coming down through a broken surface, from a distant world. I watched them for a while, then climbed down from the bunk bed and walked through them as they rose over my bare feet from the floor. For a while, before going downstairs, I stood at the window over the porch roof to see the great trucks, framed by their orange running lights, descend the long driveway and pull idling into the yard.

Dressed in coveralls and overshoes, I went out to diesel smoke in the cold air, and throbbing engines, and the drivers' faces in their mirrors as they labored at the wheels, backing around the granary, twisting the trailer so that it eased, with a sigh of air brakes, up to the wooden chute placed at the barn door, through which came the muffled sound of moving animals.

Steam filled the barn. Men and beasts moved obscurely in a white fog lit by dim bulbs, the cold air gusting through the door, heightening the smell of manure. Hooves clattered on the wooden chute. Steers tried to go up two at a time, grunting, snorting, until someone at the chute forced one of them back. The whole barn heaved and roiled. The animals approached the chute head down, legs ready to spring away, until one made the move, and then others followed.

We'd sorted them during the day, gathered them close to the barn and then walked among them, forming judgments. When young, we were just cutters, bringing the ones Dad wanted to see to his inspection, and then, if he decided, chasing them into the barn. The cattle tried to dodge back into the herd and we followed them, singling them out. Even at a young age we could tell one steer or heifer from another, and eventually we'd cut the one Dad sought. He'd look at it, make a deciscion.

As we got older we learned without formal training, simply by the repetition of finding in the herd the ones he wanted to see, to recognize for ourselves which ones were ready. Then we brought them forward without his orders, and as we got older still we joined the discussion with him, pointing out aspects to a particular steer that made it finished.

We didn't particularly like selling cattle. It was exciting, of course, the dark night, the immense trucks, the contained sense of secrecy and large event in it. But we had walked among these cattle for almost a year, pulled their ears as we paced the bunks, named many of them, learned their idiosyncracies. There was always a feeling of loss in selling. At the same time we knew it was necessary, like so many other necessary things. The day after the cattle were sold we'd all listen to the morning market reports on WCCO radio to see how well we'd done, to wonder if we could have done better.

And then, always, eithin a few months, the new calves would arrive, frightened, snorting, scouring, running from the daytime trucks that released them to huddle against the windbreak. And we would feed them. And they would grow used to us. They would grow tame. They would grow fat. Until we would walk among them, judging, dispassionate and critical, and nod our heads, and chase certain of them into the barn.

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The year after night came, my brothers and I walked alone among them, having completed the final cycle. We sold them in batches, as Dad had always done, the finished ones first, then feeding the remaining ones for a few more weeks, sorting again, feeding, the trucks coming down the long driveway, going away, coming. Like so many other things, we discovered that we knew how to do this. We no longer needed Dad to make the final decision. We could look at a steer and tell a finished one from an unfinished. It surprised us. Perhaps it shouldn't have, given how long we'd been doing it; the surprise

was in discovering what we hadn't known we knew. It was a small pleasure, and perhaps a foolish one, to discover such competency in a year of such loss.

Then the final truck came. By then the haymow was empty of all but a few bales of hay. The silo was empty. The corncribs had only a few piles left. We had planned it that way. We knew what was needed to finish the final herd.

Hooves boomed in the metal trailer. The trailer rocked and swayed. One by one the last cattle leaked away through their own fog, flesh turned insubstantial as shadow. They disappeared through the cloud of their own breath, through the chaos of their own confusion, until the barn stood empty, rags of mist in the rafters, and the sound of a diesel engine shifting through its gears and axles echoes from the county road—a rectangle of orange and red running lights, headlights pointed away. We watched. Listened. The turned toward the house. Snow creaked under our overshoes. The stars were cold.